

If I wanted to lose belly fat FAST, here's what I'd do (copy me)

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Oct 02, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-kqf1HPx3f4> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Veteran trainer Brandon Carter lays out an intentionally extreme, time-limited fat-loss protocol — steep caloric deficit, 20,000 daily steps, heavy full-body lifting, three peptides, and targeted supplements — designed to get shredded as fast as possible, not sustainably.

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Philosophy & Framing 0:00

- The protocol is **deliberately extreme and unsustainable by design** — the goal is to reach ideal weight fast, then maintain that weight
 - Being in a caloric deficit is "a mild form of starvation" by definition — there is no reason to sustain starvation indefinitely
 - Once you hit your target weight, sustain that; don't try to sustain the fat-loss process itself
- Carter's credentials: personal trainer for **27 years** (since the 1990s / Clinton administration), trained **thousands of people** from all walks of life, currently 44 years old
 - Everything in the protocol has been "battle tested" across a large and diverse population, not just himself or friends
- You cannot spot-reduce belly fat through diet and exercise
 - The only proven spot-reduction methods are cosmetic procedures: **liposuction** or **CoolSculpting** (noted to actually work for one targeted area)
 - One peptide (discussed later) has shown some spot-reduction potential in certain studies

- Disclaimer: presented as informational/educational only, not medical advice; consult a physician before acting on anything

Diet Plan: Calories & Protein 4:08

- **Calorie target:** Body weight in pounds $\times$ 10 = daily calorie ceiling. Not one calorie over.
 - Example: 250 lb person gets 2,500 calories/day
 - Example used later in the video: Carter himself eating ~2,000 calories/day
- **Protein target:** 1 gram of protein per pound of body weight per day
 - Rationale 1 — muscle retention on a cut: In a catabolic (muscle-devouring) state, very high protein preserves lean mass; building muscle vs. retaining muscle are two different things requiring different protein levels
 - Rationale 2 — satiety: Protein is far more filling than carbs; carb-heavy meals (e.g., Asian cuisine) leave you hungry again quickly
 - Rationale 3 — **thermogenic effect of food (TEF):**

Macronutrient	Calories burned in digestion
Fat	~2–3% ("almost nothing")
Carbohydrates	5–10%
Protein	20–30%

- Practical result: eat 100 calories of protein and you only net ~70–80 calories — effectively a 20–30% discount
- **Fats vs. carbs:** Carter doesn't care how remaining calories are split; he has been keto for 11 years, but says carbs are fine if preferred — calories and protein are what determine body composition
- **Why such an aggressive deficit instead of the commonly recommended 500-calorie deficit?**
 - A 500-calorie deficit is too easy to accidentally erase
 - The FDA allows food labels to be off by **up to 20% in either direction**
 - Untracked salad dressing, butter on steak, and sauces can silently wipe out a small deficit
 - A deeper deficit provides a buffer for real-world tracking errors that will inevitably occur
- Tips for adherence:
 - Eat the same foods every day when possible
 - Eliminate accidental "snacking like a child" — wait for actual meals
 - Eat your protein first at every meal
 - Track every single day without exception

Tracking Your Food 9:17

- Carter used **MyFitnessPal for 10+ years**; now tracks with **Claude** (an AI/LLM)

- Also works with ChatGPT, and likely other LLMs (Gemini, Grok mentioned)
- He provides prompt templates in the video description
- Practical tracking workflow:
 - Scan meal-prep labels and drop data into the LLM
 - **Weigh salad dressing and sauces** — this is the step most people skip that kills a small deficit
 - Track butter and cooking fats (e.g., butter on steak was 300 calories in his example)
 - End-of-day metrics review to confirm calorie and protein targets were hit
- If you don't have a food scale, take a photo of your meal and ask the AI to estimate portion weight in ounces — newer models (e.g., Claude Opus 5.5) are noted to be quite accurate at visual estimation

Cardio Plan: 20,000 Steps Per Day 11:11

- **Target: 20,000 steps per day** — walking is Carter's preferred fat-loss cardio modality
 - Burns an additional **800–1,000 calories per day** at this step count
 - Takes approximately **2.5 hours** of walking total — does not need to be continuous
- Suggested daily schedule to hit the target:
 - Wake up → walk **30 minutes** (≈3,000 steps)
 - Lunch break → walk **30 minutes** (use half of a 60-minute break)
 - After work → walk **60 minutes**
 - **Cheat code:** Walk **10 minutes every hour** during the workday — walk around the office, hallways, parking lot
- Carter notes he has coached hundreds of people who achieved this while working full-time jobs
- Why walking over other cardio?
 - Low injury risk, easy to accumulate throughout the day, doesn't meaningfully interfere with weightlifting recovery

Weightlifting Plan 12:44

- **Frequency:** 3–4 full-body workouts per week
 - Carter strongly advocates full-body training for natural (non-enhanced) athletes; has dedicated videos on this topic
- **Volume:** 1–2 exercises per body part, 3–4 sets each
- **Rest periods:** 60–90 seconds between sets — must be timed
- **Supersets:** Pair opposing muscle groups back-to-back with no rest between them
 - Example: Bench press → immediately into bent-over rows (chest + back)
 - Example: Cable bicep curls → immediately into tricep pushdowns (flip the cable attachment up)
 - This cuts total workout time significantly
- **Session length:** Keep every workout under 60 minutes

- Put the phone in the gym bag; no social media, no TikTok, no long conversations
- **Optional split:** Carter personally divides his 60-minute session into either two 30-minute sessions or three 20-minute sessions to stay fresher and maintain higher intensity throughout
- **Rep range:** 6–12 reps; never exceed 12 with a given weight
 - Pick a weight you physically cannot do more than 12 reps with
 - Do NOT turn cutting workouts into cardio by doing 30-rep sets — the muscle needs a reason (heavy load) to be retained
 - No jump squats or plyometrics in this protocol
- **Form is non-negotiable:**
 - Stop a set the moment form cannot be perfect — this is "performance failure," not muscular failure
 - Strict form prevents injury and ensures the target muscle is doing the work
 - Example of bad form: swinging elbows up during bicep curls, turning them into a full-body movement — increases injury risk without increasing bicep stimulus
 - Carter attributes his lack of major injuries after 27 years to impeccable form
- Ab training: optional 1–2 times per week
- The purpose of lifting during a cut: **retain as much lean muscle mass as possible** while the caloric deficit drives fat loss

Peptide Trifecta 16:07

Consult your physician before using any peptide. Carter frames these as game-changers that made his most aggressive cut "the easiest cut I had ever been on."

- **1. Tirzepatide (Tresipide)**
 - A GLP-1 receptor agonist — similar to semaglutide (Ozempic) but described as the newer, more advanced version
 - FDA-approved versions: **Mounjaro** or **Zepbound** (prescription required)
 - Primary effect: **dramatically suppresses appetite** — Carter had to force himself to eat enough protein because he had no hunger at all
 - Average body weight loss at highest dose tested: significant (specific % mentioned but not numerically stated beyond "impressive" in context)
 - Tested over **72 weeks** in clinical trials
 - Key warning: GLP-1 drugs suppress hunger so effectively that users who aren't tracking will fail to hit protein targets, causing muscle loss — this is why tracking becomes even more critical on a GLP-1
 - Analogy: Dieting without a GLP-1 = going to a library, using the Dewey Decimal System, checking out books, walking home, hand-writing notes, typing on a typewriter. Dieting with a GLP-1 = kid with an iPad and AI doing it from bed.
- **2. Tesamorelin**

- FDA-approved to burn **visceral fat** (fat around the organs/belly) — approval was based on studies in HIV patients
- HIV patients on tesamorelin showed **~15% reduction in visceral fat over 26 weeks**
- Mechanism: growth hormone secretagogue — stimulates the body's own natural growth hormone production
- Additional benefits reported by Carter:
 - Significantly improved sleep quality
 - Easier fat burning due to elevated growth hormone
- Analogy: Like a healthy person taking Cialis — if you don't have the deficiency, the boost takes you above baseline ("Captain America dick" framing)
- **3. MK-677 ("Matsi" / "energy in a bottle")**
 - Carter describes it as providing notably more energy
 - Particularly valuable on this protocol given the energy demands: ~2.5 hours of walking + 1 hour of lifting on only ~2,000 calories
 - Reduced his reliance on high-dose caffeine while on this compound
 - Also a growth hormone secretagogue (similar mechanism to tesamorelin)
- Combined effect of the trifecta: Carter describes the protocol as "not really difficult at all" when running all three, versus typically dreading aggressive cuts

Supplements 21:05

- **Creatine Monohydrate**
 - Standard research-backed dose: **3–5 grams/day**
 - Carter personally takes **20 grams/day** (well above standard recommendations) based on anecdotal results from bodybuilder peers and perceived personal effect
 - Studies don't confirm additional physical performance benefit at 20g vs. 5g, but newer research shows high-dose creatine may improve **cognitive function and mood**
 - Carter's take: everyone should take creatine regardless of whether they work out — beneficial for general health and brain function
- **Caffeine**
 - Carter takes approximately **1,000 mg/day** — explicitly states this is his personal dose and not a recommendation
 - Notes his cardiac health is confirmed excellent (recent EKG, monthly bloodwork, full-body MRIs)
 - Benefits: blunts hunger, increases energy, studies show it both improves athletic performance AND accelerates fat loss
 - His intake has decreased since adding MK-677
- **Whey Protein Powder**
 - Described as "non-negotiable" for hitting 1g/lb protein targets while staying within calorie limits

- Any whey protein works — it's a byproduct of the cheese manufacturing process, not a chemical
- It is the number one ingredient in infant formula — Carter uses this to rebut concerns about it being unnatural
- Not magic, but practically essential for hitting protein targets on a caloric deficit

Measuring Progress 23:22

- **Weigh yourself daily** but evaluate a **7-day rolling average**, not individual readings
 - Day-to-day weight fluctuates due to water retention, bowel movements, and other variables — the trend over time is what matters
- **Tape measure at the belly button** is considered more accurate than scale weight for tracking fat loss specifically
 - Measure from the same spot (belly button) every time for consistency
- **Progress photos** at least once per week
- Minimum recommended commitment: **30 days on the full protocol**
 - Carter's promise: follow this protocol completely and you will get "super ripped"
 - Framing: start now and by New Year's you'll already have the physique others are resolving to build